

UNION GENERAL (1786-1866)

WINFIELD SCOTT

Commissioned in 1808, Winfield Scott led a division in the Anglo-American War of 1812, helped professionalize the army after the end of that war, and conquered Mexico City in 1847 with his brilliant Veracruz Campaign. This victory made possible the acquisition of Mexican territories, such as California and New Mexico, in the American Southwest, leading to political disputes about slavery's status in these areas. At the outbreak of the Civil War, Scott was general-in-chief. Rheumatic, gout-ridden, and weighing more than 300lb (136kg), he was no longer able to take battlefield command. He resigned on November 1, 1861.



Training programs

In all theaters of the war and on both sides, soldiers drilled and organized, with varying degrees of effectiveness. In the primary Federal army in the Eastern Theater, General George B. McClellan put his army through a reasonably coherent training program; he also benefited from the North's relative abundance of equipment. Despite his hesitancy in committing troops in battle, McClellan had a real talent for organizing an army. He also played a major role in choosing the senior leaders of his force. The officers he selected for command would remain influential long after his departure. While the western Federal armies did not have the same spit and polish as McClellan's eastern showpiece, they had better organization and greater resources than their Confederate opponents.

The Confederate army facing McClellan did not receive the same systematic training, but it did benefit from a large number of Virginia Military Institute graduates who supplemented the cadre of regular officers. What later became the Army of Northern Virginia also had a disproportionate share of officers from West Point Military Academy compared to the western Confederate armies.

For Civil War armies, training centered on close order drill, which provided the methods they used to move from one position